

DEATH OF A DICTATOR

Who killed General Zia ul-Haq? This first novel by a Pakistani journalist is a brave argument with history.



A CASE OF EXPLODING MANGOES

by MOHAMMED HANIF

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■ By S. Prasannarajan

Aboard the “superfit” C130 that came crashing down in flames a few minutes after takeoff from the runway in the middle of Bahawalpur Desert in August 1988 were General Zia ul-Haq, the top brass of the Pakistani Army and the American ambassador to the Islamic Republic. Who, or what, killed the General? While professional conspiracy theorists kept us intrigued, novelists from the subcontinent did not go anywhere near the charred debris. Why the hell should they undertake such an adventure? Political whodunit is not for us, even though the history of the region is bloody and dramatic enough to inspire, say, a south-Asian version of Robert Harris, that English writer of intelligent thrillers in which merge fine journalism, superb research, and imagination. We are not particularly good at non-fictional storytelling either—no “magical journalism” of the Ryszard Kapuscinski variety or the long-form reportage that flourish in America. And it is asking for the impossible if someone is crazy enough to lament: why can’t our dictators and other paranoid fantasists get a Latin American treatment? Our story is equally fabulous; our history is populated by liberators and dreamers; and our national narratives are replete with dynasties, palace coups, assassinations and so many colliding theologies of salvation. Then, you may take consolation from the fact that Latin America itself has gone from magical realism to McRealism, in spite of the overwhelming presence of the trinity of Gabriel Garcia Marquez, Mario Vargas Llosa and Carlos Fuentes.

Mohammed Hanif, a Pakistani journalist based in London, has obviously read those Latin American

novels built on patriarchs in their autumnal hallucinations, liberators in their labyrinth and oversized dictators in their last fragile existential shell. He acknowledges his indebtedness to Llosa’s *The Feast of the Goat*, which tells the story of Rafael Trujillo, the assassinated dictator of the Dominican Republic, and Marquez’s *Chronicle of a Death Foretold*, which subverts the conventional frame of a whodunit when a murder is played out in retrospect. The General Zia of Hanif’s brilliantly executed first novel may not be exactly Trujillo or Simon Bolivar (of *The General in His Labyrinth*) or the dictator in *The Autumn of the Patriarch*, but he, a lone man caught between intimations of death and the fantasy of divine mandate, is a character to behold. And his death—or assassination?—is entangled in other marked by varying degrees of revenge, justice, ambition and betrayal.

Most notably, the story of Ali Shigri, a junior under officer at Pakistan Air Force Academy, and the son of the late Colonel Quli Shigri, a veteran of the ISI’s multi-million Afghanistan mission that set the stage for the birth of Taliban. Ali Shigri is “the one who got away”, and part of the novel is told through his voice. Still he is not the only plotter in the assassination of General Zia, but he becomes the agent that brings all swirling

subterranean conspiracies to one explosive finale. Hanif, his tone alternating between scatological and sarcastic, takes us to such forbidden territories as the torture chambers of the ISI and the bedroom of the General. In the end, how did Zia come face to face with that dark truth once revealed to him through the Koran? Was it the Shigri boy avenging his father’s murder? Was it the brotherhood within the ISI? Was it the curse of the blind girl, the jailed rape victim? Was it a communist revenge that came in the guise of a gift from All Pakistan Mango Farmers’

Cooperative? It is the narrative triumph of Hanif that he makes all possible answers indebted to the Shigri boy.

And the Zia that animates the pages of this novel is a dictator in his dark reveries. He may not be a tyrant like Trujillo who wets the bed, but Hanif’s Zia is not far off.

Paranoid, pathetic, comic, suspicious, scared, he is the Pakistani ruler who has brought Islam to the westernised, secular echelon of the military—and presided over the nascent industry of jihad. (Even Osama makes a guest appearance.) Beneath the narrator’s witty asides simmers dissent. Like some of the best from Latin America that Hanif so admires, this first novel is an

argument with a merciless history. It is absolute power that makes solitude and savagery inevitable. At last we have a Pakistani writer who faces up to his political ancestry with such explosive brio. ■



SAURABH SINGH